

26th Annual Carolina Cup

October 2–4, 2026 • Columbia & Irmo, South Carolina

Welcome to our Carolina Cup guide. We put this together so everything about the weekend — travel, lodging, the venue, and what we're still waiting on from the tournament — lives in one place instead of scattered across emails and the group chat. As the tournament releases more information, we'll send updated versions of this same guide.

At a Glance

The one-minute version. If you read nothing else, read this.

Where	Complex not yet assigned Five SCUFC complexes • Columbia / Irmo, SC
When	Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026
Bracket	Under 09 Boys Green Division
Drive	~169 miles • ~3h 15min from Savannah
Hotel	Country Inn & Suites at Harbison — \$161/night Harbison cluster • cheapest confirmed
Do today	Book the hotel — hold a free-cancellation rate while you decide
Waiting on	Game schedule & field assignments (Sep 24)

1. Tournament Quick Start

Everything a busy parent needs, in under a minute.

Event	26th Annual Carolina Cup
Host	South Carolina United FC (SCUFC)
Team	Savannah United 17/18B Blue
Dates	Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026

Venue	Complex not yet assigned Five SCUFC complexes · Columbia / Irmo, SC
Age Group	U9 • 7v7 format
Bracket	Under 09 Boys Green Division
Format	Group play → knockout rounds
Entry Fee	\$725 per team for U8–U10 (7v7)
Check-in	Online check-in only. There is no on-site check-in.
Stay-to-Play	Not published — see Section 6
Drive	~169 miles • ~3h 15min via US-17 N → I-95 N → I-26 W
Parking	Free on-site at SCUFC complexes

2. Parent Action Items

DO THIS NOW

☐ Book your hotel

Re-checked live on September 18, 2026. Our top pick is now the Country Inn & Suites at Harbison at **\$161 per night**; the Hampton Inn Harbison did not come back as available and we have withdrawn it. See Section 6 for the full list.

ACTION REQUIRED

☐ Complete online check-in

The accepted team list posted on September 14 and Savannah United 17/18B Blue is confirmed on it. SCUFC states that online check-in is open and that teams should start it **immediately**. There is **no on-site check-in** at this event, so this cannot be handled at the field. Re-verified September 18, 2026.

BRACKET POSTED — SEPTEMBER 16

☐ Know who is in your bracket

Our division is **Under 09 Boys Green Division**. Section 3 lists every team we could meet. The game-by-game schedule — pairings, kickoff times and fields — posts September 26; we'll send the updated guide with calculated departure times for each family.

BEFORE LEAVING HOME

☐ Pack using the checklist

Section 12 has the full list. Early October in the Midlands swings from about 63°F in the morning to around 80°F in the afternoon — bring layers as well as heat gear.

BEFORE LEAVING HOME

❑ Review the tournament rules

SCUFC has not published the 2026 rules document yet. Section 13 explains what we know and what we're still waiting on.

3. What We Know & What We're Waiting For

Confirmed

Official Tournament Information: 26th Annual Carolina Cup, October 2–4, 2026, hosted by South Carolina United FC in the Columbia/Irmo area of South Carolina.

Official Tournament Information: Open to boys and girls teams, U8 through U19, at Recreational, Intermediate, and Advanced levels. U8–U10 play 7v7.

Official Tournament Information: All teams must complete online check-in. There is no on-site check-in.

Official Tournament Information: Tournament director is Tripp Miller (tripp@scufc.com). SCUFC phone: 877-457-2832.

Confirmed Team Information: Savannah United 17/18B Blue is accepted and scheduled to attend.

Pending Confirmation

Confirmed: Savannah United 17/18B Blue is on the official accepted team list (09U Boys). Online check-in is required — there is no on-site check-in.

Confirmed: our bracket is **Under 09 Boys Green Division** — 8 teams in total. Opponents in our division:

- Bulls Rush U9 Boys Grey
- CESA Spartanburg U9B Pre USYS-NL 1
- CESA U9B Pre USYS-NL 2
- Lexington SA 17B White
- Savannah United 17/18B West
- SCUFC U9 Boys Green
- Spartanburg United U9 Boys White

Verified at the source on the tournament site. The game-by-game pairings, kickoff times and fields are published with the full schedule on September 26, 2026.

Confirmed now: The game schedule, opponents and field assignments are published and listed above.

Pending Confirmation: Whether a stay-to-play housing requirement applies. No policy has been published.

Pending Confirmation: The 2026 tournament rules document, including game length, mercy rule and tiebreakers.

Pending Confirmation: Coach instructions on uniform and any last team-specific details.

4. Tournament Overview

The Carolina Cup is run by South Carolina United FC and is now in its 26th year. It draws teams from across the Southeast to five complexes across

the Columbia and Irmo area, and it has been one of the region's larger youth soccer weekends for a long time. Our U9 team will play 7v7.

Official Tournament Page (SincSports):

soccer.sincsports.com — [Carolina Cup](#)

Host Club:

southcarolinaunitedfc.com

Official Rules Document:

Not yet published for 2026

5. Travel & Arrival Planning

Drive from Savannah

Route: US-17 North → I-95 North (about 80 miles) → I-26 West (about 67 miles) → US-76 into Irmo.

Total: ~169 miles. Routing re-verified September 18, 2026 (168.9 mi / 3h 12min, free-flow).

Scenario	Time	Notes
Free-flow driving	~3h 15min	Routing engine, no stops
With a fuel and rest stop	~3h 35min	Add ~20 min
Friday evening traffic	~4h 00min	Add ~45 min

Why the first number is the real one: the free-flow figure of ~3h 15min is the routing calculation for the most direct route with no stops. The 3h 35min and 4h 00min figures are our own additions for a rest stop and for Friday evening traffic — they are planning buffers, not separate route measurements.

Player Report Time

Game	Kickoff	Arrive	Depart Savannah
Saturday, October 3 vs Lexington SA 17B White Field A	8:00 AM EDT	7:15 AM	4:00 AM
Saturday, October 3 vs Bulls Rush U9 Boys Grey Field B	11:45 AM EDT	11:00 AM	7:45 AM
Sunday, October 4 vs CESA U9B Pre USYS-NL 2 Field A	1:00 PM EDT	12:15 PM	9:00 AM

Arrival is 45 minutes before kickoff. Departure is calculated from Savannah using the verified drive time of about 3h 15min (169 miles). If you are staying overnight near the venue, leave your hotel instead and ignore the departure column.

Parent Manager Recommendation: An overnight stay avoids a pre-dawn Saturday drive. Two nights (Friday October 2 and Saturday October 3) is the

pattern most traveling families use for this event.

6. Lodging

Housing requirement: SCUFC has not published a stay-to-play policy for the Carolina Cup. We checked the official tournament page, the host club site, and the registration portal, and found no stated hotel requirement or approved-hotel list. **Pending Confirmation** — we will confirm directly with the tournament director (Tripp Miller, tripp@scuvc.com) and update this section. Our recommendation is to book a cancellable rate now rather than wait.

Where to stay — rates checked September 18–19, distances verified September 19

If you are booking before September 26, book this one

The tournament does not tell us which complex our teams play at until the schedule posts on September 26. If you want to book once and not move, we would book **LivSmart Studios by Hilton Columbia Greystone**.

Why it is safe: It is the only one of the twelve hotels that stays inside our 20-mile range at **every one of the five complexes** — worst case 17.8 mi / ~24 min.

By comparison: Every other hotel, including all five featured below, falls outside 20 miles at at least one complex.

Rate: \$313 per night · \$713 for two nights, re-checked live September 19, 2026. Only 9 reviews so far and 2 rooms left at that rate — book a free-cancellation rate.

Cheaper option: La Quinta SE is \$171 / \$383 and is the closest room to our best-guess venue — but it sits about 29 miles from Ballentine and SCUFC West, so it is a bet on that guess.

Our best guess at the complex: Polo Road Park

PARENT-MANAGER RESEARCH — NOT AN OFFICIAL ASSIGNMENT

SCUFC publishes a field layout for each complex, and those layouts are labelled by field size. Polo Road is the **only complex in the set with 7v7 fields** (fields 3, 4, 7 and 8). Our four teams are U9/U10, which the tournament format table lists as 7v7. Southeastern Freight, SV Presbyterian and SCUFC West are all laid out 11v11, for the older groups. Ballentine is the other small-field complex and is the backup guess.

If that is right, **only two hotels are inside 15 miles**: La Quinta SE (11.2 mi) and LivSmart Greystone (13.9 mi). The five hotels we feature below would all be 17–20 miles out.

Before you rely on this: official complexes and field numbers publish with the schedule on September 26, 2026. Tournaments re-line fields, and the layouts SCUFC publishes are regular and practice configurations rather than the

tournament setup. Treat this as a guess that could be wrong — we will replace it with the official assignment the day it posts.

Availability was re-run for October 2–4 (one room, two adults, one child) and the driving times were confirmed separately in Google Maps. Our previous first pick, the **Hampton Inn on Harbison Blvd**, **did not come back as available**, so we have withdrawn it. **Country Inn & Suites at Harbison is confirmed at \$161 per night** and is now our top pick.

Best options right now

Country Inn & Suites by Radisson, Columbia at Harbison — our pick

Rate: \$161 per night · \$322 for two nights
Distance to field: SE Freight 8.1 mi / ~12 min · Ballentine Park 9.4 mi / ~12 min · SCUFC West 9.7 mi / ~13 min · Polo Road Park 17.2 mi / ~20 min · SV Presbyterian 21.0 mi / ~25 min

WoodSpring Suites Columbia – Irmo

Rate: \$189 per night · \$423 for two nights
Distance to field: Ballentine Park 4.4 mi / ~10 min · SCUFC West 6.9 mi / ~10 min · SE Freight 11.4 mi / ~15 min · Polo Road Park 20.5 mi / ~23 min · SV Presbyterian 24.3 mi / ~27 min

Hilton Garden Inn Columbia/Harbison

Rate: \$273 per night · \$611 for two nights
Distance to field: Ballentine Park 7.6 mi / ~10 min · SCUFC West 8.0 mi / ~12 min · SE Freight 11.0 mi / ~15 min · Polo Road Park 20.0 mi / ~23 min · SV Presbyterian 23.9 mi / ~27 min

MainStay Suites Columbia Harbison

Rate: \$279 per night · \$625 for two nights
Distance to field: Ballentine Park 8.0 mi / ~12 min · SCUFC West 8.3 mi / ~13 min · SE Freight 10.1 mi / ~15 min · Polo Road Park 19.2 mi / ~23 min · SV Presbyterian 23.1 mi / ~28 min

Hyatt Place Columbia/Harbison

Rate: \$367 per night · \$821 for two nights
Distance to field: Ballentine Park 7.9 mi / ~10 min · SCUFC West 8.2 mi / ~12 min · SE Freight 10.2 mi / ~14 min · Polo Road Park 19.3 mi / ~22 min · SV Presbyterian 23.1 mi / ~26 min

Why several distances? The Carolina Cup runs across five SCUFC complexes and the tournament does not assign our teams to one until the schedule posts on September 26. A hotel closest to Ballentine Park can be the furthest from Polo Road Park — so we show every complex rather than guess. Once each team's complex is known, that team's guide and app will lead with the hotel closest to *its* field.

Also available — further out

Comfort Suites Columbia at Harbison

Ballentine Park 8.5 mi / ~11 min • SCUFC West 8.9 mi / ~12 min • SE Freight 9.3 mi / ~13 min • Polo Road Park 18.4 mi / ~21 min • SV Presbyterian 22.3 mi / ~25 min

8.5 mi • ~11 min

LivSmart Studios by Hilton Columbia Greystone

SE Freight 6.3 mi / ~13 min • Polo Road Park 13.9 mi / ~20 min • Ballentine Park 15.2 mi / ~17 min • SCUFC West 15.5 mi / ~19 min • SV Presbyterian 17.8 mi / ~24 min

6.3 mi • ~13 min

Tru by Hilton Harbison Columbia

Ballentine Park 8.2 mi / ~12 min • SCUFC West 8.6 mi / ~13 min • SE Freight 9.9 mi / ~15 min • Polo Road Park 19.0 mi / ~23 min • SV Presbyterian 22.8 mi / ~27 min

8.2 mi • ~12 min

La Quinta Inn by Wyndham Columbia SE / Fort Jackson

Polo Road Park 11.2 mi / ~14 min • SV Presbyterian 15.1 mi / ~19 min • SE Freight 16.7 mi / ~20 min • Ballentine Park 29.3 mi / ~30 min • SCUFC West 29.6 mi / ~32 min

11.2 mi • ~14 min

SpringHill Suites by Marriott Camden

SV Presbyterian 20.7 mi / ~23 min • Polo Road Park 22.0 mi / ~24 min • SE Freight 31.0 mi / ~31 min • Ballentine Park 46.5 mi / ~45 min • SCUFC West 46.8 mi / ~46 min

Camden — allow
35–40 min

Leesville Lodge

Ballentine Park 27.0 mi / ~40 min • SCUFC West 27.5 mi / ~42 min • SE Freight 33.7 mi / ~36 min • Polo Road Park 42.8 mi / ~44 min • SV Presbyterian 46.7 mi / ~49 min

Lexington side

Motel 6 West Columbia – Airport

SE Freight 11.9 mi / ~15 min • Ballentine Park 18.4 mi / ~21 min • SCUFC West 18.8 mi / ~22 min • Polo Road Park 21.2 mi / ~23 min • SV Presbyterian 24.8 mi / ~28 min

West Columbia,
near the airport

Important: Rates were pulled live on **September 18, 2026** (La Quinta SE and LivSmart Greystone were re-checked on **September 19, 2026**) from a Hotels.com search scoped to October 2–4 for one room, two adults and one child, and will change. This is a **partial result set, not full inventory** — a hotel not listed is unknown, not necessarily sold out. Every driving time and distance below is a Google Maps figure for that hotel's verified street address, checked September 19, 2026 — now covering all five possible complexes. Book a free-cancellation rate and re-check before you travel.

PE html>

{{TEAM_NAME}}

26th Annual Carolina Cup

October 2–4, 2026 • Columbia & Irmo, South Carolina

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Bracket	{{DIVISION}}
Drive	~169 miles · ~3h 15min from Savannah
Hotel	Country Inn & Suites at Harbison — \$161/night Harbison cluster · cheapest confirmed
Do today	Book the hotel — hold a free-cancellation rate while you decide
Waiting on	Game schedule & field assignments (Sep 24)

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Everything a busy parent needs, in under a minute.

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Host	South Carolina United FC (SCUFC)
Team	{{TEAM_NAME}}
Dates	Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026
Venue	Complex not yet assigned Five SCUFC complexes · Columbia / Irmo,

SC

Age Group	{{AGE}} • {{FORMAT}} format
Bracket	{{DIVISION}}
Format	Group play → knockout rounds
Entry Fee	\$725 per team for U8–U10 (7v7)
Check-in	Online check-in only. There is no on-site check-in.
Stay-to-Play	Not published — see Section 6
Drive	~169 miles • ~3h 15min via US-17 N → I-95 N → I-26 W
Parking	Free on-site at SCUFC complexes

2. Parent Action Items

DO THIS NOW

☐ Book your hotel

Re-checked live on September 18, 2026. Our top pick is now the Country Inn & Suites at Harbison at **\$161 per night**; the Hampton Inn Harbison did not come back as available and we have withdrawn it. See Section 6 for the full list.

ACTION REQUIRED

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Our division is {{DIVISION}}. Section 3 lists every team we could meet. The game-by-game schedule — pairings, kickoff times and fields — posts September 26; we'll send the updated guide with calculated departure times for each family.

BEFORE LEAVING HOME

☐ Pack using the checklist

Section 12 has the full list. Early October in the Midlands swings from about 63°F in the morning to around 80°F in the afternoon — bring layers as well as heat gear.

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Official Tournament Information: All teams must complete online check-in. There is no on-site check-in.

Official Tournament Information: Tournament director is Tripp Miller (tripp@scufc.com). SCUFC phone: 877-457-2832.

Confirmed Team Information: {{TEAM_NAME}} is accepted and scheduled to attend.

Pending Confirmation

Pending Confirmation: Accepted team list — posted September 14, 2026.

Pending Confirmation: Bracket placement for our age group — posted September 16, 2026.

Pending Confirmation: Game schedule and field assignments — posted September 26, 2026.

Pending Confirmation: Whether a stay-to-play housing requirement applies to this event. No policy has been published.

Pending Confirmation: The 2026 tournament rules document, including game length, mercy rule, and tiebreakers.

Pending Confirmation: Coach instructions on arrival times, uniform, and team-specific details.

4. Tournament Overview

The Carolina Cup is run by South Carolina United FC and is now in its 26th year. It draws teams from across the Southeast to five complexes across the Columbia and Irmo area, and it has been one of the region's larger youth soccer weekends for a long time. Our {{AGE}} team will play {{FORMAT}}.

Official Tournament Page (SincSports):
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Host Club:
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Official Rules Document:
Not yet published for 2026

5. Travel & Arrival Planning

Drive from Savannah

Route: US-17 North → I-95 North (about 80 miles) → I-26 West (about 67 miles) → US-76 into Irmo.

Total: ~169 miles. Routing re-verified September 18, 2026 (168.9 mi / 3h 12min, free-flow).

Scenario	Time	Notes
Free-flow driving	~3h 15min	Routing engine, no stops
With a fuel and rest stop	~3h 35min	Add ~20 min
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Why the first number is the real one: the free-flow figure of ~3h 15min is the routing calculation for the most direct route with no stops. The 3h 35min and 4h 00min figures are our own additions for a rest stop and for Friday evening traffic — they are planning buffers, not separate route measurements.

Player Report Time

Pending Confirmation. Game times are released September 26. Once we have them, we'll calculate each family's departure time so players arrive at the field **45 minutes before kickoff** for check-in, warm-up, and coach instructions. That gives parents a single departure time rather than a kickoff time to do math on.

Parent Manager Recommendation: An overnight stay avoids a pre-dawn Saturday drive. Two nights (Friday

October 2 and Saturday October 3) is the pattern most traveling families use for this event.

6. Lodging

Housing requirement: SCUFC has not published a stay-to-play policy for the Carolina Cup. We checked the official tournament page, the host club site, and the registration portal, and found no stated hotel requirement or approved-hotel list. **Pending Confirmation** — we will confirm directly with the tournament director (Tripp Miller, tripp@scufc.com) and update this section. Our recommendation is to book a cancellable rate now rather than wait.

Where to stay — rates checked September 18–19, distances verified September 19

If you are booking before September 26, book this one

The tournament does not tell us which complex our teams play at until the schedule posts on September 26. If you want to book once and not move, we would book **LivSmart Studios by Hilton Columbia Greystone**.

Why it is safe:	It is the only one of the twelve hotels that stays inside our 20-mile range at every one of the five complexes — worst case 17.8 mi / ~24 min.
By comparison:	Every other hotel, including all five featured below, falls outside 20 miles at at least one complex.
Rate:	\$313 per night · \$713 for two nights, re-checked live September 19, 2026. Only 9 reviews so far and 2 rooms left at that rate — book a free-cancellation rate.
Cheaper option:	La Quinta SE is \$171 / \$383 and is the closest room to our best-guess venue — but it sits about 29 miles from Ballentine and SCUFC West, so it is a bet on that guess.

Our best guess at the complex: Polo Road Park
PARENT-MANAGER RESEARCH — NOT AN OFFICIAL ASSIGNMENT

SCUFC publishes a field layout for each complex, and those layouts are labelled by field size. Polo Road is the **only complex in the set with 7v7 fields** (fields 3, 4, 7 and 8). Our four teams are U9/U10, which the tournament format

table lists as 7v7. Southeastern Freight, SV Presbyterian and SCUFC West are all laid out 11v11, for the older groups. Ballentine is the other small-field complex and is the backup guess.

If that is right, **only two hotels are inside 15 miles**: La Quinta SE (11.2 mi) and LivSmart Greystone (13.9 mi). The five hotels we feature below would all be 17–20 miles out.

Before you rely on this: official complexes and field numbers publish with the schedule on September 26, 2026. Tournaments re-line fields, and the layouts SCUFC publishes are regular and practice configurations rather than the tournament setup. Treat this as a guess that could be wrong — we will replace it with the official assignment the day it posts.

We re-ran availability for October 2–4 (one room, two adults, one child) and the picture has changed. Our previous first pick, the **Hampton Inn on Harbison Blvd, did not come back as available** in any search, so we have stopped recommending it. The **Country Inn & Suites at Harbison is confirmed at \$161 per night** and is now our top pick — cheaper than the Hampton we had been suggesting. The **Harbison** cluster (northwest Columbia, off I-26) is where the availability is; **Irmo** itself is closest to the complexes but nearly full.

Best options right now

Why several distances? The Carolina Cup runs across five SCUFC complexes and the tournament does not assign our teams to one until the schedule posts on September 26. A hotel that is closest to Ballentine Park can be the furthest from Polo Road Park — so we show every complex rather than guess. Once each team's complex is known, that team's guide and app will lead with the hotel closest to *its* field. Every distance in this section is a Google Maps driving distance for that hotel's verified street address, re-checked September 19, 2026, and lists all five possible complexes nearest-first.

Country Inn & Suites by Radisson, Columbia at Harbison

Rate:	\$161 per night • \$322 for two nights
Area:	Harbison cluster (northwest Columbia)
Notes:	Our pick — the cheapest confirmed Harbison room
Distance to field:	SE Freight 8.1 mi / ~12 min • Ballentine Park 9.4 mi / ~12 min • SCUFC West 9.7 mi / ~13 min • Polo Road Park 17.2 mi / ~20 min • SV Presbyterian 21.0 mi / ~25 min

WoodSpring Suites Columbia – Irmo

Rate:	\$189 per night • \$423 for two nights
Area:	Irmo — the closest town to the complexes

Notes: Extended-stay style

Distance to field: Ballentine Park 4.4 mi / ~10 min • SCUFC West 6.9 mi / ~10 min • SE Freight 11.4 mi / ~15 min • Polo Road Park 20.5 mi / ~23 min • SV Presbyterian 24.3 mi / ~27 min

Hilton Garden Inn Columbia/Harbison

Rate: \$273 per night • \$611 for two nights

Area: Harbison cluster (northwest Columbia)

Notes: Restaurant on site, pool

Distance to field: Ballentine Park 7.6 mi / ~10 min • SCUFC West 8.0 mi / ~12 min • SE Freight 11.0 mi / ~15 min • Polo Road Park 20.0 mi / ~23 min • SV Presbyterian 23.9 mi / ~27 min

MainStay Suites Columbia Harbison

Rate: \$279 per night • \$625 for two nights

Area: Harbison cluster (northwest Columbia)

Notes: Suite-style with kitchenette

Distance to field: Ballentine Park 8.0 mi / ~12 min • SCUFC West 8.3 mi / ~13 min • SE Freight 10.1 mi / ~15 min • Polo Road Park 19.2 mi / ~23 min • SV Presbyterian 23.1 mi / ~28 min

Hyatt Place Columbia/Harbison

Rate: \$367 per night • \$821 for two nights

Area: Harbison cluster (northwest Columbia)

Notes: Now cheaper than when we first checked

Distance to field: Ballentine Park 7.9 mi / ~10 min • SCUFC West 8.2 mi / ~12 min • SE Freight 10.2 mi / ~14 min • Polo Road Park 19.3 mi / ~22 min • SV Presbyterian 23.1 mi / ~26 min

Also available — further out

Comfort Suites Columbia at Harbison	\$308/nt • Harbison cluster
LivSmart Studios by Hilton Columbia Greystone	\$315/nt • Greystone
Tru by Hilton Harbison Columbia	\$319/nt • Harbison — not the Greystone property
La Quinta Inn by Wyndham Columbia SE / Fort Jackson	\$171/nt • SE Columbia, longer drive
SpringHill Suites by Marriott Camden	\$213/nt • Camden, allow 35–40 min
Leesville Lodge	\$194/nt • Lexington side, basic property

Motel 6 West Columbia – Airport

\$173/nt • budget option

Marriott Bonvoy eligible from this list: SpringHill Suites Camden. The Residence Inn and TownePlace Suites in Lexington did not come back as available, and neither did the Tru by Hilton Greystone or the Ramada Limited.

Important: These rates were pulled live on **September 18, 2026** (La Quinta SE and LivSmart Greystone were re-checked on **September 19, 2026**) from a Hotels.com search scoped to October 2–4 for one room, two adults and one child, and they will change. This is a **partial result set, not full inventory** — a hotel that does not appear here is unknown, not necessarily sold out. The two-night figures include taxes and fees. Every hotel below carries its driving distance to all five possible complexes, Google Maps-verified on September 19, 2026. We show all five rather than one because the tournament has not yet assigned which complex our teams play at, and quoting a single distance would imply an assignment we do not have. Book a free-cancellation rate and re-check before you travel.

7. Weather & Heat Planning

We are nearly three weeks out, so a daily forecast is not yet meaningful. What follows is what early October has actually looked like in Columbia over the past ten years, so families can plan clothing and hydration sensibly.

Typical early-October conditions in Columbia

Afternoon high	Around 80°F on average — has reached 95°F
Morning low	Around 63°F — noticeably cool at the first game
Rain	Roughly a 1-in-6 chance of measurable rain on any given day
Sun	Strong — open complexes with limited shade
Best games	Morning games are meaningfully cooler than afternoon

What this means for packing

This is a two-wardrobe weekend. Bring the heat gear — water, electrolytes, sunscreen, cooling towels — but also bring a jacket or warm layer for early mornings and a rain shell, because October in the Midlands is not August. Start hydrating the day before travel.

Based on ten years of recorded daily observations for Columbia, SC. **Check the actual forecast around September 28–30** for reliable day-by-day conditions. Source data: Open-Meteo historical archive (2016–2025).

8. Venue, Parking & Fields

Official Tournament Information: Our team plays at **Dutch Fork High School**, 1400 Old Tamah Rd, Irmo, SC 29063. Below are all five SCUFC complexes in the area.

Ballentine Park Complex

1009 Bickley Road, Irmo, SC 29063

Listed as the tournament's primary venue on the event listing.

SCUFC West Soccer Complex

1053 Bird Road, Irmo, SC 29063

Polo Road Park

730 Polo Road, Columbia, SC 29229

Southeastern Freight Lines Soccer Center

115 Sunbelt Blvd, Columbia, SC 29203

SV Presbyterian Church Fields

125 Sparkleberry Lane, Columbia, SC 29229

Parking

Cost	Free — SCUFC complexes have on-site parking
Fill time	Fills early on tournament mornings
Fields	Grass; specific field layouts published per complex by SCUFC
Amenities	Concessions and restrooms at the complexes
Tent policy	Pending Confirmation — not published

Official field layouts (published by SCUFC):

[Ballentine Park field layout](#)

[SCUFC West field layout](#)
[Polo Road Park field layout](#)
[Southeastern Freight Lines field layout](#)

Parent Manager Recommendation: Arrive 30–45 minutes before your first game to secure parking and walk to your field. These are large, spread-out complexes.

9. Team Communication Plan

Official schedule	SincSports (Carolina Cup)
Team updates	PlayMetrics Messages • Email
Tournament logistics	Parent Manager
Soccer questions	Coach
Urgent changes	Team chat / text

An updated guide will be sent as soon as the schedule is released.

10. Coach Updates (Coming Soon)

This section will be updated once our coaches release arrival times, uniform details, and any team-specific instructions.

Parents do not need to act on these items — they are for reference once confirmed by the coaching staff.

11. Player Guidance

Tournament weekends are exciting and demanding for young players. A few practical reminders.

- Prioritize sleep — early bedtimes Friday and Saturday
- Keep meals familiar — not the weekend for new foods
- Bring simple, preferred snacks
- Encourage steady hydration through the day
- Limit exhausting hotel-pool activity before games
- Bring quiet activities for downtime between games
- Expect physical and emotional fatigue
- Keep postgame conversations positive and brief
- Let coaches handle the soccer instruction
- Emphasize effort, teamwork, learning, and fun

12. Packing Checklist

Player Gear

- ☐ Both uniform kits
- ☐ Cleats
- ☐ Shin guards
- ☐ Labeled water bottle
- ☐ Extra socks
- ☐ Warm-up / training gear
- ☐ Dry clothes
- ☐ Recovery shoes or sandals
- ☐ Personal medications
- ☐ Warm layer for early games

Weather & Hydration

- ☐ Water (plenty)
- ☐ Electrolytes
- ☐ Sunscreen (SPF 50+)
- ☐ Cooling towel
- ☐ Rain gear / shell
- ☐ Small fan
- ☐ Plastic bags for wet gear
- ☐ Extra blanket or jacket

Parent Sideline

- ☐ Folding chairs
- ☐ Umbrella
- ☐ Cooler
- ☐ Snacks
- ☐ Portable charger
- ☐ Wipes
- ☐ Trash bags
- ☐ Activities for siblings
- ☐ Cash for concessions
- ☐ Shade if permitted

Emergency

- ☐ Basic first-aid supplies
- ☐ Ice packs
- ☐ Insurance information
- ☐ Emergency contacts
- ☐ Prescriptions

13. Tournament Rules

Pending Confirmation

SCUFC has not published the 2026 Carolina Cup rules document. Game length, mercy rule, substitution rules, and the tiebreaker order are all still unconfirmed for this year.

We will not guess at these. As soon as the rules are published we'll add the full breakdown — including the complete tiebreaker hierarchy — to this section and resend the guide.

What we do know

Format	7v7 for U8–U10 age groups
Age groups	U8–U19, boys and girls

Levels	Recreational, Intermediate, Advanced
Sanctioning	US Youth Soccer affiliated (SC Youth Soccer)
Check-in	Online only — no on-site check-in

Rules questions: Tournament Director Tripp Miller — tripp@scufc.com

Bracket questions (U8–U12): Jamie McClendon — jamie@scufc.com

14. Nearby Family Resources

Distances measured from Ballentine Park Complex — the one listing sites name as the primary venue, but **only one of the five possible complexes**. Information current as of September 18, 2026.

Closest to the venue

CVS Pharmacy	0.3 mi
Food Lion	0.4 mi
Walmart Supercenter	1.1 mi • 1180 Dutch Fork Road
Publix	2.3 mi • 2732 North Lake Drive

Forgot something?

Dick's Sporting Goods	6.2 mi • 1110 Bower Parkway
Academy Sports + Outdoors	6.2 mi

Near the Harbison hotel cluster

Trader Joe's	275 Harbison Boulevard
Publix	150 Harbison Boulevard
Rite Aid	5.1 mi from the venue

15. Weekend Itinerary

Friday, October 2

Travel day for most families. Leave Savannah by early afternoon — about 3h 15min in free-flow conditions.

Saturday, October 3 — Group Play

8:00 AM EDT vs Lexington SA 17B White • Field A — arrive 7:15 AM

11:45 AM EDT vs Bulls Rush U9 Boys Grey • Field B — arrive 11:00 AM

Sunday, October 4 — Group Play

1:00 PM EDT vs CESA U9B Pre USYS-NL 2 • Field A — arrive 12:15 PM

16. Quick Reference

Screenshot this for game day.

Tournament	26th Annual Carolina Cup
Team	Savannah United 17/18B Blue
Dates	Oct 2–4, 2026
Venue	Complex not yet assigned • five SCUFC complexes
Venue confirmed	With the schedule on Sep 24
Drive	~169 mi • ~3h 15min
Hotel	Country Inn & Suites Harbison • \$161/nt
Format	U9 • 7v7
Check-in	Online only — opens after Sep 14
Weather	~63°F morning / ~80°F afternoon • layers + heat gear
Director	Tripp Miller • tripp@scufc.com
SCUFC	877-457-2832

17. Final Next Steps

- 1. Book your hotel now.** The Irmo area was 80% booked when we checked. A free-cancellation rate costs nothing to hold.
- 2. Watch for the accepted team list on September 14,** then complete online check-in. There is no on-site check-in at this tournament.
- 3. Check the bracket September 16** and the **schedule September 26.** We'll send a refreshed guide with departure times once game times are live.

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4. **Pack for two climates** — cool mornings, warm afternoons, and a real chance of rain.
-
5. **Check the forecast around September 28–30** for reliable day-by-day conditions.

Go, SU 17/18B Blue!

Looking forward to a great weekend in Columbia. Safe travels, and we'll send the updated guide as soon as the schedule drops.

Savannah United 17/18B Blue • 26th Annual Carolina Cup • October 2–4, 2026

Prepared with Bob Team Manager • Version 1.1 • Updated September 26, 2026